Present Subjunctive

WHAT IS THE SUBJUNCTIVE?
The French present subjunctive is a verb form used to express uncertainty, doubt, desire, necessity, or emotions. It is commonly used in dependent clauses, typically following certain expressions or conjunctions.

In simple terms, the present subjunctive in French indicates that the action or state described by the verb is not a certainty, but rather something **subjective** or **hypothetical**.

In French, there are certain expressions that are commonly followed by the subjunctive mood, and many of them end with the word "**que**." These expressions are often used to express **opinions**, **wishes**, **doubts**, **emotions**, and other **subjective** or **uncertain ideas**.

DISTINCTION BETWEEN THE SUBJECTS:
The subjects of the main clause and that of the dependent clause must be different. The main reason behind this rule is to clearly express the distinction between the subjective nature of the dependent clause and the objective reality of the main clause.

By having different subjects, the sentence highlights that the action or state described in the dependent clause is uncertain, subjective, or dependent on the desires, opinions, or emotions of another person or entity.

Formation of Present Subjunctive

All -ER, -RE, -IR Ending Regular Verbs

Take the present tense conjugation of third-person plural : **ils/elles** form, drop **-ent** to find the subjunctive stem and add the appropriate subjunctive ending: **-e, -es, -e, -ions, -iez, -ent**

Aimer - To love

J'aim**e**	Nous aim**ions**
Tu aim**es**	Vous aim**iez**
Il/Elle/On aim**e**	Ils/Elles aim**ent**

Attendre - To wait

J'attend**e**	Nous attend**ions**
Tu attend**es**	Vous attend**iez**
Il/Elle/On attend**e**	Ils/Elles attend**ent**

Finir - To finish

Je finiss**e**	Nous finiss**ions**
Tu finiss**es**	Vous finiss**iez**
Il/Elle/On finiss**e**	Ils/Elles finiss**ent**

Irregular Verbs

Être - To be

Je sois	Nous soyons
Tu sois	Vous soyez
Il/Elle/On soit	Ils/Elles soient

Avoir - To have

J'aie	Nous ayons
Tu aies	Vous ayez
Il/Elle/On ait	Ils/Elles aient

Aller - To go

J'aille	Nous allions
Tu ailles	Vous alliez
Il/Elle/On aille	Ils/Elles aillent

Devoir - Must

Je doive	Nous devions
Tu doives	Vous deviez
Il/Elle/On doive	Ils/Elles doivent

Pouvoir - Can/to be able to

Je puisse	Nous puissions
Tu puisses	Vous puissiez
Il/Elle/On puisse	Ils/Elles puissent

Savoir - To know

Je sache	Nous sachions
Tu saches	Vous sachiez
Il/Elle/On sache	Ils/Elles sachent

Vouloir - To want

Je veuille	Nous voulions
Tu veuilles	Vous vouliez
Il/Elle/On veuille	Ils/Elles veuillent

Venir - To come

Je vienne	Nous venions
Tu viennes	Vous veniez
Il/ Elle/ On vienne	Ils/ Elles viennent

Faire - To do

Je fasse	Nous fassions
Tu fasses	Vous fassiez
Il/ Elle/ On fasse	Ils/ Elles fassent

Usage of the Present Subjunctive

To Express a Wish or a Desire

In French, we use the subjunctive mood to express wishes or desires, because they are subjective and uncertain. The subjunctive mood conveys a sense of doubt or unreality.

When we express a wish or desire, we discuss something that may or may not happen, or something beyond our control. The subjunctive mood helps convey this uncertainty.

Some verbs used in this category are:

vouloir, préférer, souhaiter, aimer mieux… que + change of subject

Français	English
Je veux que tu fasses tes devoirs avec la même passion que quand tu joues aux jeux vidéo.	I want you to do your homework with the same passion you have when you play video games.

Pour un premier rendez-vous, **je préfère qu'on aille** dans un bar à jeux. C'est plus détendu.	For a first date, I prefer that we go to a gaming bar. It's more relaxed.
On souhaite que vous passiez de bonnes vacances en Italie.	We wish that you have a good vacation in Italy.
JM **aime mieux qu'on ne critique pas** ses mauvaises blagues.	JM likes it better that we do not criticise his bad jokes.

Note: Although Éspérer que can technically be used with both, the indicative and the subjunctive, for the sake of simplicity – try to use it with indicative only.

"J'espère que tu réussiras ton examen."
(I hope that you will pass your exam.)

Espérer - usually takes the indicative mood in French because it expresses hopes or expectations that the speaker perceives as likely or possible.

To Express Emotions

In French, the subjunctive is often used to express emotions, which can be subjective and vary from person to person. This mood allows speakers to convey their feelings, desires, and reactions in a more nuanced and personal way.

Emotions involve desires, wishes, doubts, or fears, and often relate to situations that are not yet realized or are beyond the speaker's control. Using the subjunctive mood expresses the subjective nature of emotions, emphasizing their uncertainty or the potential influence of external factors.
Most commonly used expressions to express emotions followed by subjunctive :

Français	English
regretter que	to regret that, to be sorry that
craindre que	to fear that
se réjouir que	to rejoice, to be delighted that
s'inquiéter que	to worry that
apprécier que	to appreciate that
adorer que	to love that
détester que	to hate that
s’énerver que	to be angry that
s'étonner que	to be surprised that

Français	English
Je regrette que tu ne **viennes** pas à la fête ce soir.	I'm sorry you're not coming to the party tonight.
Je **crains qu'il pleuve** demain pendant notre pique-nique.	I'm afraid it will rain tomorrow during our picnic.
Elle se réjouit que son béguin accepte de sortir avec elle	She is delighted that her crush is agreeing to go on a date with her.
Ils s'inquiètent que tu sois pas en retard pour ton rendez-vous chez le médecin.	They worry that you might be late for your doctor's appointment.
Je n'apprécie pas que mon mari ne m'**aide** pas avec les tâches ménagères.	I don't appreciate my husband not helping me with housework.
Les étudiants adorent que JM fasse toujours rire tout le monde avec ses blagues.	Students love that JM always makes everyone laugh with his jokes.
Elles détestent que le train soit en retard chaque matin.	They detest that the train is late every morning.
Tu t'énerves que les gens ne **respectent** pas les règles de conduite.	You get annoyed that people don't respect the rules of conduct.
Les amis de Soha **s'étonnent qu'elle** ne **sache** pas nager.	Soha's friends are surprised she can't swim.

With the être/ avoir + Adjective/ Noun + Que

Français	English
Être + content(e)/heureux(euse) que	to be happy that
Être + ravi(e) que	to be delighted that
Être + étonné(e) que	to be surprised that
Être + déçu(e) que	to be disappointed that
Être + triste que	to be sad that
Être + mécontent(e) que	to be dissatisfied that
Être + désolé(e) que	to be sorry that
Être + fâché(e) que	to be angry/mad that
Être + frustré(e) que	to be frustrated that

Être + furieux(euse) que	to be mad, furious that
Être + soulagé(e) que	to be relieved that
Être + surpris(e) que	to be surprised that
avoir honte que	to be ashamed that
avoir peur que	to be afraid that
avoir besoin que	to need that

Français	English
Je suis très content que tu viennes à mon mariage. Même si tu es mon ex…	I **am very happy that** you are coming to my wedding. Even though you're my ex.
JM **a besoin que ses étudiants soient** plus attentifs.	JM **needs** his students to be more attentive.
Nous sommes ravis que tu ailles en France.	We **are delighted that** you are going to France.
On est étonnés que notre nouveau voisin soit un musicien très connu.	We **are surprised that** our new neighbour is a well known musician.
Je suis déçu qu'il n'y **ait** pas de magasin bio au centre commercial.	I **am disappointed that** there are no organic shops at the mall.
Il est triste que sa copine ne **veuille** pas l'épouser.	He **is sad that** his girlfriend doesn't want to marry him.
Les parents sont mécontents que leurs enfants ne **lâchent** jamais leurs smartphones.	Parents **are dissatisfied that** their children never let go of their smartphones.
Nous sommes désolés que le musée ferme dans une demi-heure.	We **are sorry that** the museum closes in half an hour.
Je suis fâché que tu révèles tous mes secrets à tes copines.	I **am mad that** you reveal all my secrets to your friends.
Sylvie est frustrée que son mari fasse trop de bruit en mangeant.	Sylvie **is frustrated that** her husband makes too much noise while eating.
Les invités sont furieux qu'il n'y **ait** pas d'alcool à cette fête.	The guests **are furious that** there is no alcohol at this party.
Nous sommes soulagés que le projet se déroule sans aucun problème majeur.	We are relieved that the project is progressing without any major issues.

Je suis surprise que mon frère fasse la vaisselle.	I **am surprised that** my brother is doing the dishes.
Ils ont honte que leur équipe perde tous les matchs chaque année.	They are ashamed that their team loses every game each year.
Elle a peur que son mari soit coupable.	She **is afraid that** her husband is guilty.
J'ai besoin que tu termines tes devoirs avant de sortir avec tes amis.	I need you to finish your homework before going out with your friends.

To Express Doubt

In French, we use the subjunctive when we're not sure about something happening. The subjunctive mood helps to convey this sense of uncertainty. It shows that what's being described is not definite, but rather a possibility or subjective viewpoint.

Français	English
Je **doute que** mes étudiants **comprennent** tout ce que je leur explique.	I **doubt that** my students understand everything I explain to them.
Épouser quelqu'un que tu connais depuis deux semaines ? On **n'est pas sûrs que** ce soit une bonne idée.	Marrying someone you have known for two weeks? We **are not sure** if **that** is a good idea.
Si vous **n'êtes pas sûr qu'**il **mérite** ce poste, ne l'embauchez pas.	If you **are not sure** whether he deserves this post, do not hire him.
Il **n'est pas convaincu que** je **dise** la vérité.	He **is not convinced that** I am telling the truth.

Certain verbs/expressions of opinion are generally followed by the indicative mood when in the affirmative. However, in the negative form or in the interrogative, they can be followed by the subjunctive mood.

Français	English
On **pense que** ça nous **permettra** de mieux comprendre ce sujet. On **ne pense pas que** ça nous **permette** de mieux comprendre ce sujet.	We **think that** this will allow us to better understand this topic. We **don't think that** this will allow us to better understand this topic.
Je **crois qu'**il **est** toujours dans sa chambre. Je **ne crois pas qu'**il soit toujours dans sa chambre.	I **believe that** he is still in his bedroom. I **don't believe that** he is still in his bedroom.
Le policier **pense que** vous avez raison.	The police officer **thinks that** you are right.

Le policier **ne pense pas que** vous ayez raison.	The police officer **does not think that** you are right.
Crois-tu **qu'**il **sache** la vérité ?	Do you **believe that** he knows the truth?
Trouvez-vous **que** ce **soit** une bonne idée de changer de métier ?	Do you **think that** it is a good idea to change professions ?

Note: Even in the negative form, **indicative mood** can be found. In this case, it would be more of **a near certainty than a doubt**.

Français	English
Je **ne crois pas que** Daniel **est** coupable. Je **ne crois pas que** Daniel **soit** coupable.	I **don't believe that** Daniel is guilty. (I am almost sure that Daniel isn't guilty.) I **don't believe that** Daniel is guilty. (I doubt that Daniel is guilty)
Je **ne pense pas qu'**il **pleuvra** aujourd'hui. Je **ne pense pas qu'**il **pleuve** aujourd'hui.	I **don't think** it will rain today. (I am almost sure that it will not rain) I **don't think** it will rain today. (I doubt that it will rain today)

To Express a Demand/Order/Prohibition

Français	English
exiger que	to demand that
demander que	to request that
ordonner que	to order that
interdire que	to forbid that
refuser que	to refuse that

Français	English
Il **exige que** nous **soyons** à l'heure.	He **demands that** we be on time.
Ils **ont demandé qu'**on les **tienne informés** des progrès de l'enquête.	They **requested that** we **update** them on the progress of the investigation.
Le chef d'État **ordonne que** ses ministres ne s'habillent qu'en costume.	The head of the state **orders that** his minister dress up only in suits.
J'**interdis que** tu **ailles** voir ton ex.	I **forbid that** you go see your ex.

Elle **a refusé qu'**on l'appelle la nuit.	She **refused that** we call her at night.

To Express Suggestion/Proposals

Français	English
proposer que	to propose that
suggérer que	to suggest that
conseiller que	to advise that

Français	English
Je **propose que l'on aille** chez moi pour prendre l'apéro.	I **propose that** we go to my place to have drinks.
Il **suggère que** nous n'achetions pas de Mercedes.	He **suggests that** we don't buy a Mercedes.
Pour aller chez quelqu'un en soirée, on **conseille que** vous **apportiez** une bouteille de vin.	Going to somebody's place for a party, we **advise that** you take a bottle of wine.

Subjunctive with Relative Clauses (Uncertainty)

If the antecedent is clearly defined and exists, then **indicative** is used.

When the antecedent is **indefinite,** i.e. someone or something that is not yet identified or found or may never be found or doesn't exist, we use the **subjunctive** mood as the uncertainty is implied.

Français	English
Je connais un médecin qui **peut** m'aider. Je cherche un médecin qui **puisse** m'aider.	I know a doctor who can help me. I am looking for a doctor who can help me. (But I haven't found one yet.)
Je connais quelqu'un qui **sait** parler français. Je cherche quelqu'un qui **sache** parler français.	I know someone who knows how to speak French. I am looking for someone who knows how to speak French.
J'ai besoin d'un partenaire en qui je **puisse** avoir confiance.	I need a partner I can trust. (I may not find one)
Il n'y a personne qui **puisse** m'aider.	There's no one that can help me.

Il n'y a rien que les Avengers **puissent** faire ces jours-ci à cause de la pandémie.	There is nothing that the Avengers can possibly do these days due to the pandemic.
Y a-t-il quelqu'un qui **puisse** m'accompagner chez le dentiste ?	Is there anyone who can accompany me to the dentist?
Y a-t-il quelque chose qui **puisse** simplifier l'apprentissage du français ?	Is there something that can simplify the learning of French?

Multiple Subjunctives

It is possible to have multiple subjunctives in one single complex sentence. Remember, the subjunctive will be used in a particular dependent clause only if the preceding clause requires it to be followed by a subjunctive.

Français	English
Il est temps que les étudiants **demandent que** JM **fasse** de meilleures blagues en enseignant.	**It is time that** the students **ask** Joshimastar to **make** better jokes while teaching.
Il est possible qu'elle **ait besoin que** son mari **fasse** le ménage en raison de sa santé.	**It is possible that** she **needs** her husband to **do** the household tasks because of her health reasons.
Il faut que tu **exiges que** tes étudiants **soient** ponctuels.	**It is necessary that** you **demand that** your students **be** punctual.